

The Morning Briefing

US POLITICS · JUDICIARY · ISRAEL & THE MIDDLE EAST · ROME & THE VATICAN · WORLD · RESEARCH & LONG READS

THE HORMUZ STANDOFF

US and Iran trade opposing claims over the Strait of Hormuz as the 2026 war grinds on

Iran's foreign minister Abbas Araghchi said Wednesday that the United States "miscalculated" the Iran war due to "intelligence failures" and warned Washington risks an even "bigger miscalculation" over the Strait of Hormuz. Hossein Taeb, commander of the IRGC-linked Basij Organisation, claimed the strait is "under Iran's control and management." President Trump insists the United States has "total control" of the waterway. Commercial shipping through Hormuz has not recovered since strikes began in February.

Al Jazeera — aljazeera.com/news/liveblog/2026/8/13/iran-war-live-us-and-iran-exchange-opposing-claims-over-hormuz-control

US POLITICS

Leavitt to step down as White House press secretary at month's end

President Trump announced Wednesday on Truth Social that press secretary Karoline Leavitt will leave her post at the end of August. Leavitt, who gave birth to a daughter in May, said she cannot be "the best mom my two young children deserve" while carrying the job's constant demands. Trump said she will stay on as a top outside adviser and influential voice within the GOP. Her roughly eighteen-month tenure is the second-longest of any press secretary in Trump's two terms.

Axios — axios.com/2026/08/12/trump-karoline-leavitt-white-house-press

White House revives bid to remove Fed Governor Lisa Cook

An August 5 letter from deputy chief of staff Dan Scavino gives Federal Reserve Governor Lisa Cook until August 26 to respond to mortgage-fraud allegations she has never been criminally charged with and has repeatedly denied. The Supreme Court blocked Trump's first removal attempt on procedural grounds — Cook was not given notice or a chance to respond — and the new letter appears built to cure that defect ahead of a second attempt.

WHY IT MATTERS

A second, more carefully lawyered attempt to fire a sitting Fed governor over unproven claims tests whether central bank independence survives a presidency committed to unitary executive theory. See the Menand paper under Long Reads.

Axios — axios.com/2026/08/07/trump-white-house-fed-cook

SCOTUS & THE JUDICIARY

Administration presses Supreme Court on mail-in voting order

The Trump administration is urging the Supreme Court to rule on its emergency application to implement an executive order restricting mail-in voting nationwide, after the Boston-based 1st Circuit upheld a district court's block. The Court has not yet acted. The Postal Service told lower courts it cannot execute the order's requirements in time for the 2026 midterms no matter how the justices rule, with fewer than one hundred days left before the election.

SCOTUSblog — scotusblog.com/2026/08/trump-administration-urges-supreme-court-to-issue-a-decision-in-mail-in-voting-dispute

ACLU, CASA challenge new birthright citizenship order

The ACLU, NAACP and allied groups, together with the advocacy group CASA, filed motions August 11 in federal court in New Hampshire against Trump's August 6 executive order narrowing birthright citizenship for children of "birth tourists." Rather than filing a new lawsuit, they are asking the trial judge — whose earlier ruling the Supreme Court upheld in June — to hold that Trump cannot deny citizenship to anyone covered by that class ruling.

SCOTUSblog — scotusblog.com/2026/08/challenge-brought-to-trumps-new-birthright-citizenship-order

Court sets October, November argument calendars

The justices added a religious-discrimination dispute to November's argument calendar, alongside significant climate-change and immigration-detention cases already set for October.

SCOTUSblog — scotusblog.com/2026/08/court-announces-cases-it-will-hear-in-november-including-religious-discrimination-dispute

ISRAEL & THE MIDDLE EAST

Gaza strikes continue despite ceasefire; child among wounded

Israeli strikes in Gaza continued Tuesday despite the October 2025 ceasefire: a drone strike in Khan Yunis severely wounded an eleven-year-old, Khalid Shaat, and injured a child and an elderly man nearby; a separate strike on a three-wheeled transport vehicle near Beit Lahiya killed one person. The Israeli military said it targeted a Hamas militant it accused of planning an attack on soldiers. Hamas has dissolved its Gaza government but refuses to disarm, citing the continued strikes.

ANALYTICAL READ

“Targeted a militant planning an attack” is Israel’s standard post-hoc justification for strikes that also kill and wound children, and it cannot be independently verified. Hamas citing ongoing strikes to avoid disarmament, and Israel citing Hamas’s refusal to disarm to justify continued strikes, is a closed loop — and Israel, holding the military initiative, has the greater ability to break it.

Al Jazeera — [aljazeera.com/news/2026/8/12/israeli-air-strike-kills-one-in-northern-gaza](https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2026/8/12/israeli-air-strike-kills-one-in-northern-gaza)

Rome talks on Lebanon stall over Hezbollah disarmament

A seventh round of Israel-Lebanon ceasefire talks convened in Rome in early August under US mediation, aimed at expanding the “pilot zones” from which Israeli forces have progressively withdrawn to Lebanese Army control. The two sides remain split over Hezbollah’s disarmament, and Israel struck southern Lebanon at least six times during the talks, by Middle East Monitor’s count. Reporting as of August 12 describes the talks as stalled.

ANALYTICAL READ

The “pilot zone” framing casts Israeli withdrawal as a goodwill gesture on Israel’s own timetable rather than an obligation under the ceasefire it signed. Striking the other side mid-negotiation is a pressure tactic, not a security necessity — and Washington has so far declined to call it one publicly.

Al Jazeera — [aljazeera.com/news/2026/8/5/lebanon-and-israel-still-split-over-disarming-hezbollah-at-rome-talks](https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2026/8/5/lebanon-and-israel-still-split-over-disarming-hezbollah-at-rome-talks)

West Bank: troops clash with settlers over illegal outpost

Israeli troops clashed with Jewish settlers who had erected an outpost directly in front of Palestinian homes in the West Bank; the military ultimately withdrew after failing to clear the settlers. Vatican News separately reported that Christians in the town of Taybeh feel “forgotten” amid settler violence.

Times of Israel — [timesofisrael.com/liveblog-august-13-2026](https://www.timesofisrael.com/liveblog-august-13-2026)

ROME & THE VATICAN

Pope Leo XIV: Sunday Mass “cannot be substituted” by virtual presence

At his August 12 general audience in St Peter’s, continuing his catechesis on chapter five of the conciliar document *Sacrosanctum Concilium*, Pope Leo XIV said “the encounter

with Jesus, who died and rose again for us, is the purpose that the Church always pursues, placing the celebration of the Paschal event at the centre of every moment.” He called Sunday assembly for the Eucharist irreplaceable, warning it “cannot be substituted by a solely virtual presence,” and urged parishes to find “the best possible conditions” so Christians who must work Sundays can still attend Mass.

Vatican News — [vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-08/pope-at-audience-the-liturgical-year-renews-christ-s-saving-work.html](https://www.vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-08/pope-at-audience-the-liturgical-year-renews-christ-s-saving-work.html)

Pope names three historians to Pontifical Committee for Historical Sciences

Pope Leo appointed Umberto Longo, director of the Italian Historical Institute for the Middle Ages in Rome; Francesco Cesareo, president emeritus of Assumption University in Worcester, Massachusetts; and Anna Barańska of the John Paul II Catholic University of Lublin, Poland, to the Pontifical Committee for Historical Sciences. Founded in 1954 by Pius XII, the committee traces its lineage to a Cardinal Commission for Historical Studies established by Leo XIII in 1883 and oversees scholarly access to the Vatican Archives. It is chaired by the Jesuit Fr Marek Inglot.

Vatican News — [vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-08/pope-appoints-three-members-pontifical-committee-historical.html](https://www.vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-08/pope-appoints-three-members-pontifical-committee-historical.html)

Pope to spend Assumption at Castel Gandolfo

Pope Leo will spend the Solemnity of the Assumption, August 15, at Castel Gandolfo, remaining there through August 18. Cardinal Secretary of State Pietro Parolin said this week that “peace begins with empathy for the suffering of others,” addressing both the Rome-hosted Lebanon talks and the wider regional violence.

Vatican News — [vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-08/pope-leo-to-return-to-castel-gandolfo-until-18-august.html](https://www.vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-08/pope-leo-to-return-to-castel-gandolfo-until-18-august.html)

WORLD NEWS

Pope sends aid as Colombia earthquake toll passes 130

Pope Leo sent financial aid to Colombia after a major earthquake struck the country’s west; the confirmed death toll has passed 130 with nearly 600 injured. The Archbishop of Manizales called the quake “extremely devastating.”

Vatican News — [vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-08/pope-leo-financial-aid-colombia-earthquake.html](https://www.vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-08/pope-leo-financial-aid-colombia-earthquake.html)

Pope appeals for “conversion of those who sow violence”

Following his August 9 Angelus, Pope Leo appealed for “the conversion of those who sow violence” amid ongoing wars in Sudan, Ukraine and Russia, calling for an end to the conflicts.

Vatican News — [vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-08/pope-leo-stop-spiral-of-violence-and-make-room-for-diplomacy.html](https://www.vaticannews.va/en/pope/news/2026-08/pope-leo-stop-spiral-of-violence-and-make-room-for-diplomacy.html)

RESEARCH & LONG READS

Menand: unitary executive theory can’t coexist with an independent Fed

Lev Menand’s “The Unitary Executive and the Federal Reserve” (Fordham Law Review, vol. 94, 2026) argues that unitary executive theory — which would let the president remove independent agency heads at will — is fundamentally incompatible with central bank

independence, and that none of the proposed carve-outs for the Fed hold up under the theory's own logic. Directly relevant to the Lisa Cook fight above.

Fordham Law Review — fordhamlawreview.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/04/Vol-94_Issue-6_2_Menand-Online-Ready.pdf

Mapping the New Right's rival factions

"The Right-Wing Intellectuals Who Keep Winning" (Oxford Political Review, 2026) sorts the New Right into three rival camps — Claremonters around Michael Anton, postliberals

such as Patrick Deneen, J.D. Vance and Adrian Vermeule, and national conservatives around Yoram Hazony — who share a rejection of liberal pluralism but disagree sharply on what should replace it, from "aristopopulism" to religious nationalism. Useful for placing this week's executive-power fights within the movement's internal arguments over state power.

Oxford Political Review — oxfordpoliticalreview.com/2026/03/31/the-right-wing-intellectuals-who-keep-winning